

Limitations

This analysis is limited because the GradCafe dataset is based on anonymous, self-reported submissions, which may be incomplete, inaccurate, or biased. Applicants may exaggerate or misreport their GPA, GRE scores, or admission status, and many entries are missing fields entirely. In addition, users who choose to post on GradCafe are not representative of all applicants, since highly motivated and/or high-achieving students are more likely to report their statistics as a result. The database reflects a selective sample rather than something like a census.

Some of the analytics results, such as a relatively high average GRE and GPA values, differ from official national statistics and were somewhat surprising, like a GRE of 4 in one entry, or a GRE AW score of 99, which is impossible, so the averages are going to be skewed. The average GRE AW score was 8, which is impossible as 6 is the highest score. Not only is a lot of data inaccurate, but the entries are usually concentrated around certain competitive programs and institutions, which inflates average metrics. Differences in reporting standards, incomplete records, and inconsistent terminology also contribute to variation between this dataset and official sources.